us, may have been made known, or made more explicit, to those unfamiliar with the correspondences by those disseminating Ashoka's message.

The one thing we know for certain about Ashoka's first message is that its wording and meaning was, for the average person, unlike anything that had in the past formed the day-to-day reality of royal rule. While kingship had a distinguished antiquity in large parts of Ashoka's empire, going back in fact many centuries prior to Mauryan rule, a king was not prone to confiding the life-changing episodes of his career to his people. As warrior and protector of his realm and subjects, as also a supreme arbitrator of their disputes, he was meant to project himself as powerful, not spiritual. The people may have had to be forgiven if they were confused by a king who, instead of proclaiming his strength via grandiloquent titles, alluded to himself humbly as 'beloved of the gods'. The very thought of such a man being their ruler will have run contrary to normal thought processes within the populace, which, on the odd occasion that it thought of him at all, perhaps only feared him as a kind of god at the apex of a tax-extracting administration backed up by an army, the dread lord who might some day rain down on them with his soldiers for reasons unanticipated. The power and persona of such rulers was mediated on the ground by various administrative functionaries. Villagers and townspeople would normally have been familiar only with local functionaries, not with the monarch. Now, through this novel intervention, the ruler had brought himself within the direct ambit of their world. The situation will have seemed bewildering, the imperial initiative without precedent.

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The vast bulk of Ashoka's subjects, not being mobile or itinerant, are only likely to have been familiar with at most one of his edicts, the one located closest to them—it being understood, of course, that very many are likely not to have been familiar with any. Those who encountered the first minor